

Argos and the Lost Keepsake

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, brave, and keeps faith with a friend. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.



Argos and the Lost Keepsake

Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

The ships are nearly ready to sail home across the sea. There is happy bustle all along the Ship Camp, with sails being mended and figs being packed. But near one tent sits your friend Lykos, and he is crying.

"I have lost my keepsake," he says. "A little token, carved from olive wood, that my grandmother gave me. I carried it all this long way, and now it is gone, somewhere out on the windswept shore. We sail at sunset. I cannot leave it behind."

Odysseus the Clever kneels beside you. "A friend is sad, and a treasure is lost," he says. "That is a job for clever heads and faithful hearts. Will you go and find it before the ships sail?"

He gives you three gifts: the Conch Horn, the Basket of Honey and Figs, and Penelope's Thread. Then he whistles, and up trots a loyal old dog with a grey muzzle and a wagging tail.

"This is Argos the Faithful Hound," says Odysseus. "He never forgets a friend or a scent. Follow his nose, follow each other, and leave no one behind."

What is your hero name? Will you be a hero of Cleverness, of Courage, or of Loyalty?

Stop 1: Following Argos



Argos puts his nose to the sand and sets off along the beach. He stops at a little mark in the sand, then at another, then he looks back at you and waits.

There are tracks here, and small clues too: a dropped fig, a footprint, a scuff where someone sat down to rest.

What could you do? Could you look closely at the tracks with Argos and read which way your friend walked? Which clues point one way, and which point the other?

When you follow the right trail, Argos gives a happy little bark and trots on. You are on the scent now.

Stop 2: The Tide Pools



The trail leads you in among the sunlit rock pools, where the sea has left little ponds full of shells and crabs. The keepsake brushed past one of these pools, but which one?

There are three pools. Beside the first lies a white shell. Beside the second lies a striped shell. Beside the third lies a smooth grey pebble.

Argos sniffs and tells you two things. The scent went past a striped shell, not a white one. And the scent did not stop where the pebble was.

Can you remember the clues? Which pool had the striped shell and no pebble? That is where your friend rested, and dropped a thread from his cloak.

When you work out the second pool, you find the thread caught on a rock, pointing the way on. Argos wags his tail. Well thought!

Stop 3: The Far Dune



The trail ends at a lonely dune, far along the shore, where the wind has been piling the sand all day. Somewhere here the keepsake fell, and the wind has half buried it.

Argos sniffs in big circles, then stops at one spot and looks at you, ears up.

What could you do? Could you watch where Argos points his nose and dig there, very gently, together? Look for a corner of olive wood in the sand.

When you brush the sand away, there it is: the little carved token, warm from the sun. Argos digs the last of it free with one careful paw and drops it into your hands.

Nobody Left Behind



You hurry back along the shore to the Ship Camp, the keepsake held safe. When Lykos sees it, his face lights up like the sunrise.

"You found it! You came back for it!" he cries, and he hugs the little token, and then he hugs Argos, who wags so hard he nearly falls over.

Odysseus the Clever smiles and says, "You did not leave a friend behind. That is the truest kind of clever there is." Out on the bright waves, Thetis the Sea-Mother lifts her gentle face and smiles upon you.

The ships can sail home now, every friend and every treasure safe aboard. Well done, heroes. Well done, Argos. Nobody was left behind.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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